women are a key constituency that the party has systematically targeted between 2004 and 2020. They are at the vanguard of the party's rise as India's pre-eminent political formation. While the BJP had always had women leaders—starting with the Gwalior royal Vijaya Raje Scindia from the Jan Sangh days; Sushma Swaraj, who moved from the Janata Party after 1980; and Uma Bharati, who became a star campaigner during the Ram Temple movement—it had suffered from a gender gap in its support base. Until 2014, more men used to vote for it than women.

There was a dramatic gender shift in 2019, when more women voted for the party than men for the first time. The making of a new women's vote was the foundation for Modi's re-election in 2019. It was driven by three factors: Modi's personal political outreach to women through a discourse focused on the glorification of women's achievements, a major shift in the representation of women in elections and internal party organisation, and specific policy initiatives by the government aimed at women.

New research in this chapter shows that, by 2020, the party organisation had more women's representation in its central decision-making levels than any other national political party in India. This was accompanied by a new strategy for reserving a significant share of party positions for women at all levels of party organisation—down to the voting-booth level. Similarly, both Modi governments, NDA-1 and NDA-2, had a slightly higher proportional representation of women ministers (12.7 per cent on average) when compared to Manmohan Singh's two UPA governments (11.2 per cent on average), and significantly higher than Vajpayee's BJP-led NDA government (9 per cent).

In policy outcomes too, women beneficiaries had a large share in general non-women-specific Modi-government schemes: 81 per cent of the total financial beneficiaries in Stand Up India, 68 per cent of loans under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana and 53 per cent of banking accounts under the Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana (PMJDY). A whopping 11.4 million (66.9 per cent) of 17.1 million rural houses sanctioned under PMAY-G were registered in the names of women individually or as joint holders with their husband. This government decision to privilege poor women in the registration